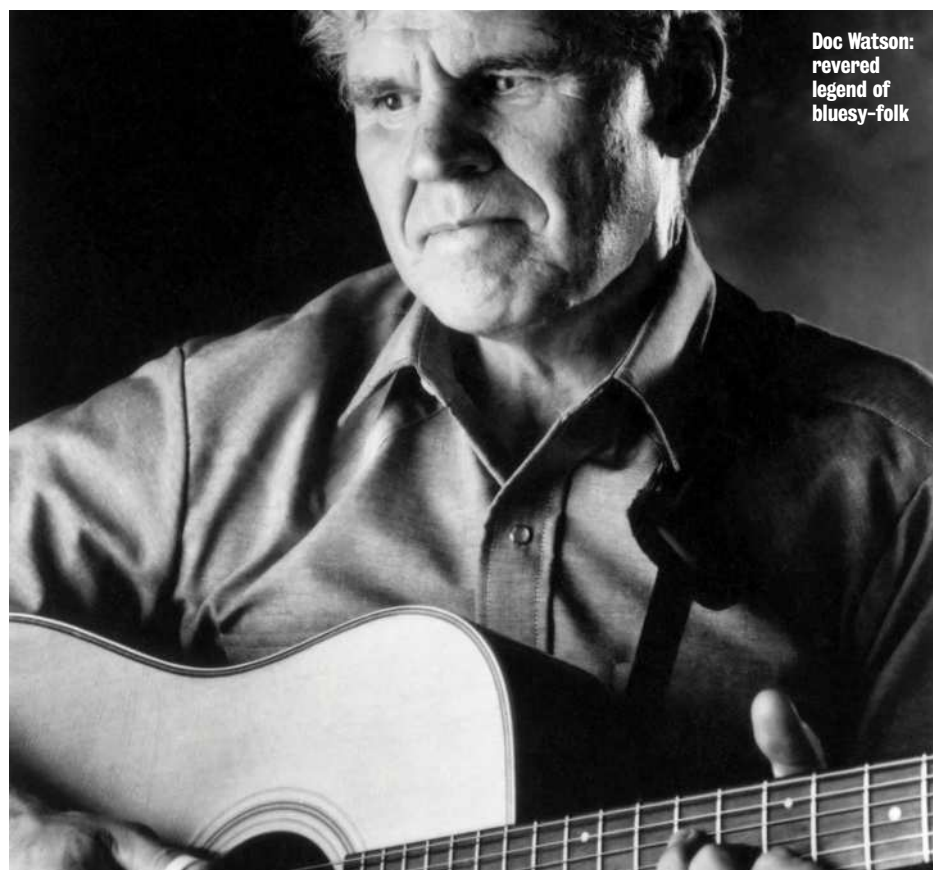


Doc Watson

Over the next six pages we examine a style of music that became known as Americana, with some neat picking from two cool dudes.



Doc Watson:
revered
legend of
bluesy-folk

his son Merle and bassist T Michael Coleman and, even though the folk revival lost its momentum in the late '60s, Watson flourished and released many new recordings while still touring hard. He was a undoubtedly a great influence on other legendary pickers, most notably Clarence White of 'Sweetheart Of The Rodeo' era Byrds, and the great contemporary bluegrass guitarist, Tony Rice.

Watson was a skilled musician and highly-regarded within traditional American music circles. He was an expert plectrum

“He was a great influence on other legendary pickers, most notably Clarence White of The Byrds”

player, Travis picker, banjoist, harmonica soloist and singer. His popularity never waned and each year he hosted Merlefest, an acoustic festival established in the memory of his son Merle, who died in 1985. The festival attracts up to 70,000 fans each year and is one of the most successful in the acoustic world.

There are many inspirational aspects to Doc's playing, but perhaps it's his fluency as both a flatpicker and Travis picker that marks him out from many of his contemporaries. Doc died on May 29, 2012 in North Carolina. To find out more visit www.docsguitar.com. **SR**

Info	Will improve your...
KEY Various	✓ Flat picking
TEMPO 220 bpm	✓ Travis picking
	✓ General fluency

Blind country-blues and bluegrass dynamo Doc Watson died in 2012 shortly before his 90th birthday and following sharp on the heels of another pioneer of the style: banjo bluegrass legend, Earl Scruggs. In the following piece we'll look at two key facets of Watson's style – his mastery of the plectrum technique and his love of Travis picking.

Arthel Lane 'Doc' Watson was born in Deep Gap, North Carolina in 1923. He was blind from a very early age but this did not impair his ability to teach himself the guitar so, armed with a cheap Stella acoustic, he began to learn

the music of his early country influences: the Carter Family (with picker extraordinaire Maybelle Carter on guitar) and the legendary 'Singing Brakeman', Jimmy Rodgers.

Watson's career began on the street corners of his home town, but it wasn't long before the young guitarist was spotted by a local western swing band. Ironically, much of his early professional career was spent playing fiddle tunes – on a Les Paul! Switching to acoustic he discovered his signature sound, but retained the fiddle tunes, simply transferring them to acoustic. Bear in mind that in the early days of country the guitar was generally used as a back-up tool, so to play fiddle melodies on the instrument was something that set Watson apart, right from the outset.

His big break came when he appeared at the Newport Folk Festival in 1963. He followed this the following year with the release of his first solo album. He began to perform as a trio with

Get the tone

Doc's first quality guitar was a Martin D-18 but in 1968 he established a long-standing relationship with Gallagher guitars. An American sounding dreadnought is perfect but any acoustic will do. Watson developed a powerful playing style, probably as a result of poorly amplified acoustic guitars and the need to 'project'. Dig in hard and think more about delivery than out-and-out perfection.



LISTENING SUGGESTIONS For some modern tasty picking check out Doc's playing with Bryan Sutton on *Whiskey Before Breakfast*, from the latter's album, *Not Too Far From The Tree*. You can't go wrong with The Nitty Gritty Dirt Band's classic 1972 live album, *Will The Circle Be Unbroken*; or perhaps a 'greatest hits' such as Doc's *Prescription: 40 Bluesgrass Classics*. There are many impressive performances of him online too, so check him out.

EXAMPLE FLAT PICKING

[Bar 1] We are in flatpicking territory here, so aim for steady alternate picking and a relaxed picking hand throughout.

[Bar 9] Watch out for the triplet; you should be playing with a slight swing feel but you may find that you get locked into the constant eighth notes so the

triplet feel takes you by surprise with its sudden acceleration.

[Bars 10-17] This sequence simply outlines the underlying chords but listen to masters like Doc and they throw in some unexpected chromaticism (non-scale notes), often to maintain the flow of a line.

$\text{♩} = 220$ **G**

D G

D G C D

G C D G

EXAMPLE FLAT PICKING

[Bar 1] Here is some Doc Watson-style Travis picking based on the changes to his classic Deep River Blues. Again a slight swing feel or even swagger is important to get the authentic delivery in place. Don't forget to palm mute the bass notes for a nice bit of added 'thump'.

[Bar 2] One of the hardest elements of Travis picking to get dead right is the syncopation – the notes that fall 'off' the beat. The bassline is always 'on' the beat but listen to how the melody notes often fall between it timewise.

As for technique, Doc generally used the first and second fingers (i and m) on his picking hand to pluck the top three strings, while the thumb (with a thumbpick, although this is not vital) played the bass notes.

[Bar 12] Subtle bluesy quartertone bends are another feature of Doc's style, as witnessed here. These are harder to play as the bends are on the first and second strings at the same time. This will take some strength and control, so work up to the required tempo slowly.

EXAMPLE FLAT PICKING

Tempo: ♩ = 190

PM bass notes throughout

Chords: E7/G#, Edim7, E7, A7, E, B7/F#, B7, E7#9, E6

Staff 1 (Measures 1-4):

- Measure 1: E7/G# (7 5 7 6)
- Measure 2: Edim7 (6 5 5 6)
- Measure 3: E7 (4 3 4 2)
- Measure 4: A7 (3 0 2 0)

Staff 2 (Measures 5-8):

- Measure 5: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 6: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 7: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 8: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 3 (Measures 9-12):

- Measure 9: E7/G# (7 5 7 6)
- Measure 10: Edim7 (6 5 6 5)
- Measure 11: E7 (4 3 4 2)
- Measure 12: A7 (3 0 3 0)

Staff 4 (Measures 13-16):

- Measure 13: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 14: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 15: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 16: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 5 (Measures 17-20):

- Measure 17: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 18: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 19: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 20: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 6 (Measures 21-24):

- Measure 21: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 22: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 23: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 24: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 7 (Measures 25-28):

- Measure 25: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 26: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 27: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 28: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 8 (Measures 29-32):

- Measure 29: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 30: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 31: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 32: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 9 (Measures 33-36):

- Measure 33: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 34: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 35: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 36: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 10 (Measures 37-40):

- Measure 37: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 38: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 39: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 40: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 11 (Measures 41-44):

- Measure 41: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 42: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 43: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 44: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 12 (Measures 45-48):

- Measure 45: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 46: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 47: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 48: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 13 (Measures 49-52):

- Measure 49: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 50: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 51: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 52: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 14 (Measures 53-56):

- Measure 53: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 54: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 55: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 56: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 15 (Measures 57-60):

- Measure 57: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 58: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 59: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 60: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 16 (Measures 61-64):

- Measure 61: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 62: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 63: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 64: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 17 (Measures 65-68):

- Measure 65: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 66: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 67: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 68: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 18 (Measures 69-72):

- Measure 69: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 70: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 71: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 72: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 19 (Measures 73-76):

- Measure 73: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 74: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 75: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 76: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 20 (Measures 77-80):

- Measure 77: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 78: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 79: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 80: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 21 (Measures 81-84):

- Measure 81: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 82: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 83: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 84: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 22 (Measures 85-88):

- Measure 85: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 86: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 87: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 88: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 23 (Measures 89-92):

- Measure 89: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 90: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 91: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 92: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 24 (Measures 93-96):

- Measure 93: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 94: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 95: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 96: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)

Staff 25 (Measures 97-100):

- Measure 97: E (0 0 1 2)
- Measure 98: B7 (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 99: B7/F# (0 2 2 1)
- Measure 100: E7#9 (3 0 0 1)